

Ecclesiastical Latin

EL-I.5: Fourth and Fifth Declensions

Recognize fourth- and fifth-declension forms and discriminate look-alike endings across all five noun declensions

Stage	Stage I — Foundations
Prerequisite	EL-I.4 mastery: recover third-declension stems and apply neuter and i-stem rules
Next	EL-I.6, Adjectives and Agreement

Read *EL-GUIDE: Start Here* before using this packet. Course method, pacing, source conventions, and answer protocol are stated there; this module begins with its lesson and assumes previously taught terms.

Contents

I	Lesson	1
1	Unit 5: Fourth and Fifth Declensions	1
1.1	Fourth-declension forms	1
1.2	Fifth-declension forms	1
1.3	A five-declension decision procedure	2
1.4	Handwritten study and controlled composition	2
II	Practice	3
1	Transfer, retrieval, and application	3
1.1	Fourth-declension forms — transfer practice	3
1.2	Fifth-declension forms — transfer practice	3
1.3	A five-declension decision procedure — transfer practice	3
1.4	Handwritten study and controlled composition — transfer practice	3
III	Worksheets	4
1	Unit 5: Fourth and Fifth Declensions	4
	Worksheet I.17 — Variant A	4
	Worksheet I.20 — Variant D	5
IV	Assessment	6
1	Mastery assessment and record	6
V	Answer Key	7
1	Practice models and rubrics	7
2	Unit 5: Fourth and Fifth Declensions	8
	Solution I.17 — Variant A	8
	Solution I.20 — Variant D	9
VI	Scope and Sources	10
1	Scope and Qualifications	10
1.1	Packet boundary	10
1.2	Controlling records and local state	10
2	References	10
2.1	Primary corpus	10
2.2	Grammar and lexicography	11
2.3	Citation convention	11
3	Generation Metadata	11

Part I

Lesson

CHAPTER 1

Unit 5: Fourth and Fifth Declensions

On completing this unit, you can:

- identify fourth- and fifth-declension nouns from their dictionary forms;
- decline masculine and neuter fourth-declension nouns and a regular fifth-declension noun;
- distinguish identical-looking forms by syntax; and
- choose a defensible case analysis for nouns from all five declensions.

1.1 Fourth-declension forms

The fourth-declension marker is genitive singular *-us*. Most nouns in *-us* are masculine, but *manus*, *manus f.*, “hand”, is a frequent exception. Neuters such as *genu*, *genus n.*, “knee”, obey the universal neuter rule: nominative and accusative are identical, and their plural ends in *-a*.

<i>spiritus, spiritus m.</i>			<i>genu, genus n.</i>	
	sg.	pl.	sg.	pl.
Nom.	spiritus	spiritus	genu	genua
Gen.	spiritus	spirituum	genus	genuum
Dat.	spiritui	spiritibus	genu	genibus
Acc.	spiritum	spiritus	genu	genua
Abl.	spiritu	spiritibus	genu	genibus
Voc.	spiritus	spiritus	genu	genua

Length marks would distinguish several forms in a fully marked dictionary, but ordinary Missals omit them. Therefore *spiritus* can be nominative singular, genitive singular, nominative plural, accusative plural, vocative singular, or vocative plural. Government, agreement, and clause function must decide among them.

1.2 Fifth-declension forms

The fifth-declension marker is genitive singular *-ei*. Most nouns are feminine. *dies*, *diei*, “day”, is usually masculine, though it can be feminine when it denotes an appointed day. The regular model is *res*, *rei f.*, whose broad range includes “thing, matter, affair”, and “reality”.

<i>res, rei f.</i>		
	sg.	pl.
Nom.	res	res
Gen.	rei	rerum
Dat.	rei	rebus
Acc.	rem	res
Abl.	re	rebus
Voc.	res	res

Worked example: *Et cum spiritu tuo*

Worked passage ID: W.I.16; exact source and collation state are recorded in the passage inventory.

cum governs the ablative. Thus *spiritu* is ablative singular, and possessive adjective *tuo* agrees with it in masculine singular ablative. Translation: “And with your spirit.”

Worked example: *Pater, in manus tuas commendo spiritum meum*

Worked passage ID: W.I.17; exact source and collation state are recorded in the passage inventory.

The movement into another’s keeping makes *in* govern accusative *manus*; it is feminine plural, so *tuas* agrees with it. *spiritum meum* is the masculine singular accusative object of *commendo*. Translation: “Father, into your hands I commend my spirit.”

Worked example: *Hæc est dies quam fecit Dominus* (Ps 117:24)

Worked passage ID: W.I.18; exact source and collation state are recorded in the passage inventory.

dies is nominative singular and the predicate noun after *est*. Relative *quam* is feminine accusative singular because it refers back to *dies* as conceived here and is the object of *fecit*. Translation: “This is the day which the Lord has made.”

Worked example: *Ut in nomine Iesu omne genu flectatur* (Phil 2:10)

Worked passage ID: W.I.19; exact source and collation state are recorded in the passage inventory.

in governs ablative *nomine*; *Iesu* is genitive singular. Neuter *genu* is nominative singular, the subject of passive *flectatur*; *omne* agrees with it. Translation: “That at the name of Jesus every knee should bend.”

1.3 A five-declension decision procedure

For every noun, first write its dictionary genitive and gender. Derive the stem, then let syntax select case and number before selecting an ending. Do not assign a case from the ending alone. For example, *-ibus* narrows a form to dative or ablative plural, but a governing *cum* settles the choice; a recipient may instead require the dative. Treat irregular *domus*, *domus f.* as a dictionary item: its forms mix second- and fourth-declension patterns.

1.4 Handwritten study and controlled composition

Copy the three paradigms, circling every form that can represent more than one case or number. Make a one-page five-declension chart containing only genitive singular, dative singular, accusative singular, ablative singular, and nominative plural endings. Then write and label *cum spiritu*, *in manibus*, *in manus*, *rei bonæ*, and *res bonæ*. Transform *Hæc est dies* to *Hi sunt dies*; transform *omne genu* to *omnia genua*.

Part II

Practice

CHAPTER 1

Transfer, retrieval, and application

1.1 Fourth-declension forms — transfer practice

Connection. Fourth-declension *-us* and *-u* forms are best learned as coordinates in a paradigm, not as isolated endings.

Transfer task. Make a two-column matrix for the lesson's masculine and neuter fourth-declension models. Highlight every nominative–accusative identity and every form that can express more than one case or number.

Retrieval check. State the neuter rule and identify the dictionary form that distinguishes fourth declension from a superficially similar second-declension noun.

1.2 Fifth-declension forms — transfer practice

Connection. The small fifth declension contains high-frequency words whose forms can resemble endings from other classes.

Transfer task. Build the full lesson paradigm for *res* from memory, then annotate which cells would remain ambiguous if the dictionary entry and clause were hidden.

Retrieval check. Give the genitive and dative singular endings and explain how agreement can help distinguish a fifth-declension form in context.

1.3 A five-declension decision procedure — transfer practice

Connection. A look-alike ending matrix makes ambiguity explicit before context resolves it.

Transfer task. Create rows for *-a*, *-ae*, *-i*, *-is*, *-us*, *-u*, *-es*, and enter at least two possible declension/case/number analyses where the lesson permits them. Apply the matrix to the lesson's five-declension review phrases.

Retrieval check. Recite the decision order: dictionary evidence, morphological possibilities, clause function, agreement, and government.

1.4 Handwritten study and controlled composition — transfer practice

Connection. Number transformations expose whether the learner controls both rare paradigms and their agreement partners.

Transfer task. Complete the lesson's *dies* and *genu* transformations, drawing a box around every noun ending and an arrow to each word whose agreement must also change.

Retrieval check. Name one unchanged lexical stem and one changed grammatical coordinate in each transformation.

Part III

Worksheets

CHAPTER 1

Unit 5: Fourth and Fifth Declensions

Worksheet I.17 — Variant A

Worksheet ID: I.17

Focus: Fourth/fifth forms and five-declension discrimination

Use: Write gender as well as case and number.

1. Give genitive singular, dative singular, accusative singular, ablative singular, and genitive plural of *spiritus*, *spiritus m.*.

-
2. Give nominative/accusative singular, nominative/accusative plural, genitive plural, and dative/ablative plural of *genu*, *genus n.*.

-
3. Decline *res*, *rei f.* in the singular in case order.

-
4. Parse and translate *cum spiritu tuo*; explain why *spiritum* would be wrong.

-
5. Correct *hæc est diem quam fecit Dominus*.

-
6. Text: *Pater, in manus tuas commendo spiritum meum*.

Passage ID: I.17.1; exact source and collation state are recorded in the passage inventory.

Parse the fourth-declension nouns, explain both adjective forms, and translate.

Worksheet I.20 — Variant D**Worksheet ID:** I.20**Focus:** Rare declensions in high-frequency liturgical phrases**Use:** Treat every form as part of the complete noun system.

1. Write the full singular and plural paradigms of *genu*, *genus* n..

-
2. Write genitive singular, dative singular, accusative singular, ablative singular, and genitive plural of *dies*, *diei* m..

-
3. Explain how context distinguishes *res* in *res bona est*, *videt res bonas*, and *res bonæ sunt*.

-
4. Translate “the spirit of truth”, “to the Holy Spirit”, and “the knees of the servants”.

-
5. Diagnose *cum Spiritum Sanctum* and *rei bonus*; correct both.

-
6. **Text:** *Ut in nomine Iesu omne genu flectatur*.

Passage ID: I.20.1; exact source and collation state are recorded in the passage inventory.

Parse *nomine*, *Iesu*, *omne genu*, and the finite verb; translate.

Part IV

Assessment

CHAPTER 1

Mastery assessment and record

Advance when: Write the three displayed paradigms with at least 95 percent accuracy, list all possible analyses for 18 of 20 mixed-declension forms, and select the contextual analysis in at least nine of ten short phrases.

Complete the assessment before opening the answer part. Record evidence, not confidence or elapsed time.

Evidence	First attempt	Delayed check
Date and conditions		
Worksheet ID and score		
Mastery task and result		
One recurring error family		
Correction stated as a rule		
Unseen or remediation item used		

If the criterion is met: continue to EL-I.6, Adjectives and Agreement.

If it is not met: Worksheets I.18 and I.19 remain optional remediation or delayed-recall variants.

Advance / remediate decision: _____ **Next review date:** _____

Reason in one complete sentence: _____

Part V

Answer Key

Open this part only after completing the assessment record. Use the comparison and alternative-answer protocol in EL-GUIDE.

CHAPTER 1

Practice models and rubrics

Fourth-declension forms — model and rubric

Model / acceptable evidence. The matrix must preserve the lesson paradigms and mark neuter nominative and accusative identity. The genitive singular in *-us*, together with the full dictionary pair, identifies fourth declension; the nominative alone does not.

Fifth-declension forms — model and rubric

Model / acceptable evidence. The paradigm must give genitive and dative singular *rei*. A correct explanation uses an agreeing adjective or demonstrative plus clause function to narrow the analysis; it does not claim that one English gloss proves the case.

A five-declension decision procedure — model and rubric

Model / acceptable evidence. The matrix must not collapse genuinely different analyses. Each applied decision must cite the noun's dictionary genitive first and then syntactic evidence. The stated order must preserve morphology before translation.

Handwritten study and controlled composition — model and rubric

Model / acceptable evidence. The lesson models yield plural *Hi sunt dies* and *omnia genua*. The analysis must keep the stems stable, identify number as the changed coordinate, and account for agreement in the accompanying demonstrative, verb, or adjective.

CHAPTER 2

Unit 5: Fourth and Fifth Declensions

Solution I.17 — Variant A

Worksheet ID: I.17

Focus: Fourth/fifth forms and five-declension discrimination

Use: Write gender as well as case and number.

1. Give genitive singular, dative singular, accusative singular, ablative singular, and genitive plural of *spiritus*, *spiritus m.*

Answer / model: *spiritus*, *spiritui*, *spiritum*, *spiritu*, *spirituum*.

2. Give nominative/accusative singular, nominative/accusative plural, genitive plural, and dative/ablative plural of *genu*, *genu n.*

Answer / model: *genu*; *genua*; *genuum*; *genibus*.

3. Decline *res*, *rei f.* in the singular in case order.

Answer / model: *res*, *rei*, *rei*, *rem*, *re*, *res*.

4. Parse and translate *cum spiritu tuo*; explain why *spiritum* would be wrong.

Answer / model: *spiritu tuo* is masculine singular ablative after *cum*: “with your spirit”. *spiritum* is accusative, which *cum* does not govern.

5. Correct *hæc est diem quam fecit Dominus*.

Answer / model: *Hæc est dies quam fecit Dominus*. Predicate noun *dies* must be nominative after *est*; *quam* remains accusative object of *fecit*.

6. Text: *Pater, in manus tuas commendo spiritum meum*.

Passage ID: I.17.1; exact source and collation state are recorded in the passage inventory.

Parse the fourth-declension nouns, explain both adjective forms, and translate.

Answer / notes: *manus*: feminine plural accusative after directional *in*; *tuas* agrees. *spiritum*: masculine singular accusative object; *meum* agrees. “Father, into your hands I commend my spirit.”

Solution I.20 — Variant D

Worksheet ID: I.20

Focus: Rare declensions in high-frequency liturgical phrases

Use: Treat every form as part of the complete noun system.

1. Write the full singular and plural paradigms of *genu*, *genus* n..

Answer / model: Singular: *genu*, *genus*, *genu*, *genu*, *genu*, *genu*. Plural: *genua*, *genuum*, *genibus*, *genua*, *genibus*, *genua*.

2. Write genitive singular, dative singular, accusative singular, ablative singular, and genitive plural of *dies*, *diei* m..

Answer / model: *diei*, *diei*, *diem*, *die*, *dierum*.

3. Explain how context distinguishes *res* in *res bona est*, *videt res bonas*, and *res bonæ sunt*.

Answer / model: First *res* is nominative singular; second is accusative plural; third is nominative plural. Verb number and adjective endings resolve the identical noun form.

4. Translate “the spirit of truth”, “to the Holy Spirit”, and “the knees of the servants”.

Answer / model: *spiritus veritatis*; *Spiritui Sancto*; *genua servorum*.

5. Diagnose *cum Spiritum Sanctum* and *rei bonus*; correct both.

Answer / model: *cum Spiritu Sancto*, ablative after *cum*; *rei bonæ*, feminine singular genitive or dative agreement.

6. **Text:** *Ut in nomine Iesu omne genu flectatur*.

Passage ID: I.20.1; exact source and collation state are recorded in the passage inventory.

Parse *nomine*, *Iesu*, *omne genu*, and the finite verb; translate.

Answer / notes: *nomine*: neuter singular ablative after *in*; *Iesu*: genitive singular; *omne genu*: neuter singular nominative subject; *flectatur*: third-person singular present passive subjunctive. “That at the name of Jesus every knee should bend.”

Part VI

Scope and Sources

CHAPTER 1

Scope and Qualifications

1.1 Packet boundary

This is module EL-I.5, *Fourth and Fifth Declensions*, in Triptych's print-first Ecclesiastical Latin curriculum. It imports one authoritative lesson, transfer practice for its internal submodules, two selected worksheets, one local mastery assessment, and matching solutions. This packet completes the ordinary five-declension map while keeping rare lexical behavior dependent on the identified dictionary entry.

The unprinted worksheet variants remain course-owned extension material; their omission is intentional and is not a claim that the module exhausts available practice. EL-GUIDE owns the course-wide study method, pacing, lookup discipline, answer protocol, source classes, and advancement rules; this packet assumes that orientation and terminology taught in prerequisite modules.

1.2 Controlling records and local state

Course-wide research records own the edition, passage, answer, curriculum, and source decisions; the leaf's module map records this packet's selection and transfer practice. EL-GUIDE owns the corpus, normalization, translation, non-authority, review, and answer conventions that apply here. Claim-local qualifications remain beside the affected material; check received wording against the course-wide passage inventory.

Any installed snapshot is a working study held from release until its exact bytes and outstanding distribution gates receive separate authorization.

CHAPTER 2

References

The following works are the course's controlling corpus and reference aids. Project-composed explanation, translation, analysis, exercises, and models are distinguished from received wording under the convention stated in the Scope and Qualifications appendix. Short source passages are identified so that the learner can verify their wider context. The adjacent edition manifest and passage inventory record exact source roles, checks, access states, and known rights limits.

2.1 Primary corpus

- Catholic Church, *Missale Romanum ex decreto SS. Concilii Tridentini restitutum, Summorum Pontificum cura recognitum*, editio typica (Rome, 1962). A searchable presentation of the edition is hosted by the Holy See's Biblia Clerus project: <https://www.clerus.org/bibliaclerusonline/EN/gmb.htm>.
- A page-image scan of the 1962 typical edition is available through the Church Music Association of America: <https://media.churchmusicassociation.org/pdf/missale62.pdf>. Page images, rather than unsourced transcriptions, should decide doubtful punctuation or spelling.

- The Clementine Vulgate is the principal biblical comparison corpus. The public-domain 1914 edition edited by Michael Hetzenauer and its provenance are described at <https://www.sacredbible.org/vulgate1914/>.

2.2 Grammar and lexicography

- J. H. Allen and J. B. Greenough, *New Latin Grammar for Schools and Colleges* (1903), a donor-declared public-domain reference whose digital locator was not independently consulted during integration: <https://archive.org/details/allengreenoughsn01alle>.
- Charles E. Bennett, *New Latin Grammar*, 1918 revision, Project Gutenberg eBook 15665; public-domain text in the United States: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/15665>.
- Charlton T. Lewis and Charles Short, *A Latin Dictionary* (1879), searchable transcription: <https://logeion.uchicago.edu/lexidium>.
- Charles du Fresne, sieur du Cange, *Glossarium mediae et infimae latinitatis*, a donor-declared later-vocabulary aid whose digital locator was not independently consulted during integration: <http://ducange.enc.sorbonne.fr/>.

The underlying 1903, 1918, 1879, and 1883–1887 printed works are public domain in the United States. Digital transcriptions and interfaces retain their own terms and are cited as access tools, not relicensed or reproduced wholesale. The 1962 Missal, Scripture, official text, and other received wording retain their own status; see the scope appendix, research records, and final-page rights notice.

Classical reference grammars describe the inherited system but do not by themselves explain every biblical or ecclesiastical development. The advanced volume therefore distinguishes classical baseline, Vulgate usage, later Christian usage, and stable liturgical formula instead of labeling every difference an “exception.”

2.3 Citation convention

Missal passages are cited by liturgical location and text genre rather than by a page number that varies among printings. Biblical texts are cited by book, chapter, and verse. Historical authors are cited by work and section wherever possible. A learner preparing a formal commentary should verify each passage against the edition actually being used and record any variant. These references are not a claim that every historical-linguistic question can be settled by the listed school grammars and dictionary interfaces.

CHAPTER 3

Generation Metadata

Last revised (UTC): 2026-07-21T17:50:56Z

Model: GPT-5-based Codex agent; unexposed: exact model identifier and model qualifiers

Agent/runtime: OpenAI Codex agents (curriculum architecture, module design, enrichment, source and answer audit, correction, production, and review); Codex CLI 0.144.6; API workspace; unexposed: server revision

Agent/runtime: OpenAI Codex agents (whole-curriculum structure audit, shared typesetting and selection correction, rendered-structure regression checks, production, and review); Codex CLI 0.144.6; API workspace; unexposed: server revision

Agent/runtime: OpenAI Codex agents (whole-curriculum Part-scoped numbering and rendered contents hierarchy correction, rendered contents-geometry regression checking, production, and review); Codex CLI 0.144.6; API workspace; unexposed: server revision

Agent/runtime: OpenAI Codex agents (starter-guide consolidation, module-flow and definition-retrieval revision, stage-boundary assessment correction, catalog and audit records, production, and review); Codex CLI 0.144.6; API workspace; unexposed: server revision

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